

Jim Pham
Autobiography
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A brief description of who you are

I was born in Vietnam. I grew up with two brothers and two sisters. We immigrated to America in 1980 as refugees. My father was a Captain in the South Vietnamese Army, and he was captured by the communists after the Vietnam War in 1975 and sent to a re-education camp for thirteen years. My family was finally united upon his release in 1988 after he escaped Communist Vietnam and came to America. My mother was a housewife. Though they had limited education themselves, they instilled in me the values of intellectual achievement and of using whatever talents I possessed.

We started our new life in America without any money. For a long time, we were able to survive through government-subsidized income and housing. My siblings and I were educated in the public school system. Our family moved from Columbus, Ohio to San Jose, California in 1986. I graduated from Silver Creek H.S. in 1987 and attended San Jose State University. I received B.S. and M.S. degrees in Computer Engineering. Fortunately for me, my college education was mostly paid for by Cal Grant and other low-income financial aid. Otherwise, the cost of an education would have been prohibitive for my siblings and me. Even though my parents had a limited education, all of us graduated with college degree(s). My two brothers and I graduated with engineering degrees; one sister graduated with an advanced degree in education; and my older sister graduated with an accounting degree. I was the first in my family to earn a college degree and the first in my generation to attend college.

For the past fifteen years, I have worked in the computer industry as a hardware-software design engineer. My most recent employers included Oracle and PeopleSoft. I also spent five years at Lockheed and IBM. I have extensive software design experience in object-oriented programming, User Interfaces, internet technologies, and multi-platform tools. In addition, I taught for eight years as an Adjunct Instructor at Ohlone College. Throughout my professional career, I submitted five patent applications, published many hardware/software design patterns, and hand-coded millions of lines of code in C/C++, .NET, and J2EE/Java.

Your experience with online education

This class is my third online course. My experience with online education was through the Alliant International University courses. I just finished two online courses, and it was a pretty rough adjustment for me due to workload and family responsibilities, but I successfully managed to balance work, family, and schoolwork. Regardless of my busy schedule, I enjoyed taking these two courses and the convenience and flexibility they offer.

Dissertation ideas or topic

In the area of integrating computer technology and the Internet, I have extensive practical experience using the Internet to deliver teaching and learning. For this reason, I want to focus on technology as a basis for my dissertation topic. Furthermore, I want to incorporate technology into the teaching and learning environment. One of my recent projects, my team and I wrote an article on online student services as a new way to deliver campus-based student services. I want to take this idea one step further and create a comprehensive online teaching and learning solution for educational institutions.

Explain your experience with the study of technology and its uses

As mentioned in the section above, I have extensive experience and practical knowledge of computer technology and the Internet. In my experience, I designed computer hardware—computer systems, motherboards, and network devices. In addition, I also designed many software applications. For all these reasons, I understand technology products and the underlying technology behind them.

What you hope to learn in this class

My greatest strengths have long been in information technology, so I hope to continue to deepen my understanding of how to integrate it in schools and classrooms. Furthermore, I hope that online learning will reach and serve a much broader student population, including non-traditional students, with a wider array of curriculum options, thereby enhancing the likelihood of student success. Finally, I hope that online learning will provide a high-quality learning experience for anyone, anywhere, on any path.